

Teaching Philosophy

Kingsford Onyina

Ph.D. Candidate, Public Policy Analysis

University of North Carolina at Charlotte

"A teacher affects eternity; he can never tell where his influence stops."

Henry Adams

I experienced the enduring influence Henry Adams describes through a high school economics teacher who redirected my academic trajectory. I vividly remember how he used economic tools and real-world examples to uncover the intuition beneath concepts that had previously seemed abstract, with his lesson on the price mechanism remaining especially memorable. For a student accustomed largely to rote learning, his approach felt like putting on prescription glasses for the first time: ideas became connected, intelligible, and useful. I began approaching economics, and eventually my other courses, with greater curiosity about the reasoning behind what I was learning. Although I had initially felt lost in the class, I earned the second-highest economics score that semester and received a small journal he awarded to the top three students. That gesture affirmed my potential and motivated me to persist, ultimately graduating with highest honors. Much of who I am academically began in that classroom. His influence anchors my teaching philosophy: rigorous expectations should be accompanied by the clarity, structure, and encouragement students need to recognize themselves as capable learners.

That formative experience gained a formal foundation at the University of Education, Winneba, where my economics degree incorporated training in pedagogy, human development, instructional design, and assessment. At the same time, moving from secondary-school economics to the greater quantitative demands of university study required me to adapt how I learned difficult material. That transition made me attentive to the varied preparation, confidence, and prior exposure students bring into the classroom. Together, my pedagogical training and experience as a learner taught me that mastery of content is only one component of effective instruction. Teaching must also make the purpose, structure, and logic of challenging material visible so that students with different starting points can work toward the same rigorous standards.

Making the Path to Understanding Visible

My teaching begins with the substantive question a concept or method is intended to address. Before introducing a formal model or technical procedure, I help students understand the problem that makes the tool necessary. I then use familiar examples, visual explanations, guided applications, and real economic and policy questions to connect intuition to formal analysis. Demanding tasks are divided into coherent stages, with the reasoning behind each stage made explicit before support is gradually reduced. My goal is not for students merely to reproduce a procedure, but to explain why it is appropriate, identify its assumptions, interpret the evidence it produces, and recognize its limitations.

This approach shaped a guest lecture I delivered on causal inference for public policy. Rather than beginning with a catalogue of estimators, I started with the distinction between association and causation and introduced identification strategies as responses to concrete research problems. Students have similarly noted that my review sessions condense several weeks of material into a coherent structure, present the full sequence of steps, and explain difficult ideas through multiple examples. This commitment to clear and structured delivery extends beyond my formal classroom responsibilities.

Also, over the past four years, I have built an online educational community of more than 66,000 subscribers, with content on graduate education reaching audiences across more than 30 countries and receiving over 2 million views. Graduate admissions confront prospective students with an avalanche of information about program selection, funding, application requirements, timelines, and unfamiliar institutional expectations. Developing this content has strengthened my ability to identify what learners need most, organize large amounts of information into coherent stages, anticipate confusion, and preserve depth without overwhelming the audience. I bring the same discipline to my classroom by carefully sequencing material, clarifying connections among ideas, and helping students distinguish essential concepts from surrounding detail.

Pairing High Expectations with Meaningful Support

Students do not enter the classroom with identical preparation or ways of learning. Some respond quickly to formal models, while others develop understanding through discussion, application, visual explanation, or repeated practice. My own academic transition taught me not to confuse speed with ability or initial difficulty with limited potential. I therefore treat approachability and intellectual challenge as complements. I expect sustained effort, but I also create clear opportunities for students to ask questions, receive feedback, and revise their understanding.

Teaching across Ghana and the United States, and across economics, sociology, data analytics, and public policy, has reinforced the importance of adapting instruction without compromising rigor. As instructor of record for an asynchronous Quantitative Analysis course serving primarily sociology students, I relied on deliberate sequencing, clearly signposted explanations, consistent communication, and opportunities for direct support. In office hours and review sessions for econometrics and health economics, I help students locate where their reasoning changed direction, reconstruct the argument step by step, and leave with a strategy for moving forward rather than simply an answer.

My evaluations reflect the environment I seek to create. I received ratings of 4.30 out of 5 as instructor of record for Quantitative Analysis and 4.55 out of 5 for my support in Health Economics. Students have described me as energetic, passionate, supportive, and approachable, while emphasizing my use of real-world examples, thorough explanations, and willingness to present concepts in different ways. For me, encouragement is most valuable when paired with clear expectations and actionable feedback. I want students to leave an interaction feeling supported, but also knowing precisely what they need to do next.

Preparing Students to Reason Across Disciplines

Public policy classrooms bring students from different disciplinary traditions to shared social problems. During my doctoral qualifying examinations, I organized and frequently led study sessions for colleagues trained in sociology, public administration, business, political science, and geography. I helped the group prepare for the Economic Analysis for Public Policy and Quantitative Analysis components by translating technical concepts across disciplinary vocabularies, identifying gaps in understanding, and explaining methods through multiple points of entry. This experience confirmed that interdisciplinary teaching is not merely about simplifying material. It requires recognizing how prior training shapes the way students approach the same analytical problem and building bridges among those perspectives.

My broader objective is to move students from supported understanding to independent judgment. In public policy, technical competence matters only when students can ask appropriate questions, assess evidence, recognize uncertainty, and communicate conclusions to varied audiences. These capacities are increasingly important in the era of generative artificial intelligence. When explanations, code, and apparent answers are readily available, students must learn to identify hidden assumptions, verify results, and use emerging tools to support rather than replace their reasoning.

My commitment to accessible, rigorous instruction also extends beyond the classroom. I founded the QuantBridge Applied Quantitative Webinar Series alongside my co-founders to connect experienced economists and policy analysts with early-career researchers through free training in applied quantitative methods. Sessions have covered standard and staggered difference-in-differences designs, instrumental variables, and regression discontinuity. The inaugural session attracted more than 150 participants from over 17 countries, many from the Global South, where access to specialized methodological training is often limited. QuantBridge represents my teaching philosophy at a larger scale: a researcher's location, institutional affiliation, or previous access should not determine whether they can acquire the tools needed to conduct credible policy research.

My interdisciplinary training prepares me to teach Introduction to Public Policy, Public Policy Analysis, Research Methods for Public Policy, Quantitative Methods of Program Evaluation, Microeconomic Foundations or Economic Analysis of Public Policy, Social Welfare Policy, and Applied Econometrics. I would also develop Causal Inference for Policy Evaluation, focused on contemporary quasi-experimental methods, and Public Policy and the Life Course, examining how the design and timing of policy exposure shape individual and family outcomes over time and across generations.